

Why Russia Misjudged Ukraine: Assumptions, Information and Military Failure

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Russia's invasion of Ukraine exposed striking deficiencies to the Russian military. Prior to February 2022, the size, scale and capabilities of the Armed Forces of the Russian Federation (AFRF) were feared and venerated by Western leaders, analysts and the press. However, in war, material military muscle only goes so far, and despite being consistently outmanned and outgunned, the Armed Forces of Ukraine (AFU) have muddled the Russian campaign with failures. Constructed on flawed intelligence, false assumptions and fragile planning, the Kremlin failed to recognise Ukraine's determination to succeed in an existential war, as well as inherent and systemic weaknesses within the AFRF. This essay analyses the performance of the AFRF through strategic, operational and tactical levels of warfare, seeking to explain why Russia failed to crush Ukraine as anticipated. To conclude, I will argue that the fundamental explanation to the poor performance of the AFRF is deeply rooted within political and military doctrine, culture and history, and is not unitarily identifiable, measured, or solvable.

It is important to note the difficulty of finding reliable information regarding the Ukrainian war. This is partly due to the conflict's recency, which has limited the number of trusted and reviewed literature. However, what has been published is often filtered through narratives that serve political aims. The rise of communication technologies, namely the internet, has created a new civil-military bargaining relationship in the West (Coletta and Feaver 2006). Military autonomy has ceded to 'hundreds of millions of electronic eyes and ears [that] are creating a capacity for scrutiny and new demands for accountability.' (Gowing 2009, 1) The Ukraine war has accentuated the importance of information in mobilising political, financial and military support towards a conflict. The US and EU have committed approximately €100bn in military, financial and humanitarian assistance to Ukraine; (Kiel Institute for the World Economy 2022) for this support to continue, western civil societies must remain engaged and empathetic to Ukraine's defence. Consequently, western publications can be influenced by biases that wish to strengthen such support and combat opposing Russian propaganda. This essay relies on dependable journalistic, think tank and news outlets, but the accuracy and narrative of these sources should be openly scrutinised and questioned. Nevertheless, the main conclusions and points of this essay are built upon observations of the Ukraine War which have been confirmed by multiple sources.

Through placing attention on the expected speed of Russian success, this essay will focus on the invasion's intended initial course of action- to capture Kyiv and decapitate Ukrainian command. To stay concise, detailed, and within the wordcount, analysis will centre on the faults of the Russian military, as opposed to the Ukrainian defence. Antithetical to the AFRF, performance

of the AFU has been much better than expected (Berg and Radin 2022). Demonstrating impressive adaptability, self-control, and determination, the AFU appears to have swung momentum to their side in the conflict, regaining territory in the Kharkiv, Luhansk, and Kherson regions (Congressional Research Service 2022). The AFU have also effectively integrated Western aid, equipment and training into their fighting (Davydenko, Khvostva and Lymar 2022; Berg and Radin 2022). President Zelensky has deftly channelled admiration and support in Western culture for himself and his cause; (Shuster 2022) some have labelled him a 'Ukrainian Churchill', portraying the tale of the democratic underdog and offering a popular channel for aid (Cohen 2022). However, while the remarkable defence of Ukraine is of course a key determinant in Russian military failure, there are weaknesses in the Russian military system that surprised the world and warrant discussion. Should these flaws have been absent, one may argue that Kyiv will currently be under Russian occupation, implying de facto control over Ukraine. Therefore, for lack of a longer wordcount, this essay will focus on the performance of the AFU. However, comprehension of the AFU's performance is required for a full understanding of the conflict.

The strategy of the Russian campaign was built upon several false premises and assumptions regarding Ukrainian and Western weakness versus relative Russian strength. As Freedman writes, 'Putin made the familiar but catastrophic mistake of underestimating the enemy, assuming it to be weak at its core, while having excessive confidence in what his own forces could achieve.' (Freedman 2022, 12) Kremlin overconfidence was likely influenced by previous campaigns of the AFU, chiefly, the annexation of Crimea in 2014. Contrasting the current performance of the AFU, 2014 Crimea witnessed a quick and efficient invasion using next-generation Russian warfare (Dalsjö, Jonsson and Norberg 2022, 13). The deployment of a nimble, highly trained covert operational force alongside long-range precision artillery allowed Russia to shape the Crimean battlefield through tactics of subversion and psychological warfare (Kofman et al. 2017, 23). Success in Crimea operations will have influenced the Kremlin's judgment of the efficacy of the tools and tactics in their arsenal. This confidence would have only been boosted further by Russia's military intervention in Syria, that propped up Bashar al-Assad's regime through the employment of minimal ground forces beside effective air and artillery operations (Kaim and Tamminga 2015).

The Kremlin's rose-tinted gaze extended beyond military means and onto the public mood and political air of Ukraine. The minimal bloodshed and largely unhostile reception to Russian troops throughout the Crimea annexation will have strengthened the perception of support or apathy for invasion; Russian troops even received the moniker the 'polite people' from bloggers and media in Crimea (Lidz 2015). This plays into Putin's narrative of social and cultural homogeneity across Ukraine and Russia. Putin believes 'Ukraine is not just a neighbouring country', but 'an inalienable part of' Russian 'history, culture and spiritual space': Ukrainians 'are our comrades, those dearest to us – not only colleagues, friends and people who once served together, but also relatives, people bound by blood, by family ties.' (Putin 2022, 1) He contends that modern

Ukraine is historically part of Russia: it was wrongly created by the Bolsheviks and has since been manipulated by the West and an oligarchic Ukrainian elite who incite ‘aggressive Russophobia and neo-Nazism.’ (Putin 2022, 3) To Putin, Russians and Ukrainians ‘all know these facts...this is common knowledge.’ (Putin 2022, 1) Thus, the defence of a historically Russian populace and culture provided the Kremlin with the ethical and moral justification for invasion. This narrative was strengthened through an information and propaganda campaign targeting audiences across Russian and Ukrainian civil societies (Ogrysko 2016). Prisoners and intercepted communications show that Russian soldiers sincerely believed that Ukrainians would greet them as liberators (Johnson 2022, 8). This perception had damaging effects on discipline, morale and drilling, with Russian soldiers not mentally or physically preparing themselves for hostility (Kaplan 2022).

The notion that the Russian invasion could enjoy support or acceptance from a substantial Ukrainian population is delusional (Szostek 2022). The course of the Ukraine war attests to the falsity of this ‘common knowledge’: opposed to being welcomed as liberators, the Russian invasion force was greeted with common abhorrence and hostility. In a survey, 80% of Ukrainian respondents stated they were ready to defend the territorial integrity of their country with weapons in hand (Szostek 2022). Seth G. Jones argues that the widespread and organised resistance from the Ukrainian population resembles what Mao Zedong referred to as a ‘people’s war’, where invaders find themselves surrounded and ‘burned to death’ by a hostile mass of native resistance (Jones 2022, 6). Other theorists like Antulio J. Echevarria II have delineated a strong Clausewitzian ‘warlike element’ within the fierceness of Ukraine, signifying the extensive motivation, morale, and enmity towards Russia (Echevarria II 2022). Evidently, there was a critical misreading of Ukrainian public opinion, unity and strength within the Kremlin.

Hence, the subsequent strategy of the Kremlin contained not only an inflated view of their military capability, hooked on the ideas of next-generation warfare, but also a severe underestimation of Ukrainian resistance. The result was ‘a conviction at the top that if the door was kicked in the whole building would collapse.’ (Dalsjö, Jonsson and Norberg 2022, 13) The ensuing blueprint for invasion necessitated a short and decisive war shaped around rapid operations by elite combat units and precision artillery, (Freedman 2022, 19) initiating with a dicey *coup de main* bid to take Kyiv (Dalsjö, Jonsson and Norberg 2022, 13). There was no readily executable backup plan, or any notion of long-term planning should the war be drawn out. Kremlin faith was so strong that no central military commander was appointed to the campaign. Despite employment of all five Russian military districts in the invasion, the first six weeks saw no unity of command, denoting an absence in synchronisation across the separate axes of invasion (Cooper and Schmitt 2022).

Deprived strategy and planning translated to major deficiencies at the operational level. The Russian airborne force, VDV, spearheaded the invasion, reinforced by a drive of armoured columns from the Belarusian border (Reynolds and Watling 2022, 3). On the first day of the campaign, VDV units directed a helicopter assault on Hostomel Airport in broad daylight (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 26). The seizure of Hostomel airport was determined a key aim by the AFRF in order to create an air bridge just West of Kyiv (Australian Army Research Centre 2022, 14). The AFU anticipated the assault, cratered the runway and bolstered defence. The resulting battle was a 'bloody fiasco' for the Russians (Spoonts 2022). Several VDV helicopters were shot down, while landed units came under heavy artillery fire and were cleared by a subsequent counterattack force (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 26). Reportedly, eighteen Il-76 aircraft were turned back as a result of the airfield being inoperative, denying Russia a key logistical hub and air-lift destination (Australian Army Research Centre 2022, 14). The failed assault emphasises the risk of forward assault operations against explicit positions, as opposed to broader axes, reflecting the broader fragility of the Kyiv-centred approach to the invasion (Australian Army Research Centre 2022, 26).

The Hostomel fiasco also stressed the importance of effective air support. The Russian Airforce (VKS) were expected to quickly overwhelm 'Ukraine's meagre air defences', (Kofman and Edmonds 2022) establish air superiority and coordinate with ground operations. Instead, VKS air operations were swiftly muted by unneutralised air defences (Jones 2022, 4). Lacking superiority, air attacks were limited to expensive missile barrages pursuing pre-designated targets (Jones 2022, 1). Ineffectuality was compounded by poor battle damage assessment. Russian forces consistently presumed that if an action had been ordered and carried out then it has succeeded, unless there is direct evidence to the contrary (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 25). This denotes a lack of coordination between air and ground operations, leaving forward ground units isolated and vulnerable.

Ground forces also struggled with unexpectedly competent resistance. Equipped with an ignorance for Kyiv's transport routes and the local terrain, armoured columns found their advance largely confined to predictable road routes (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 3). Confused by the enemy's dispersed position and movements, units were critically exposed to Ukrainian artillery, anti-tank teams and ambush (Cranny-Evans 2022). As a senior adviser to General Zaluzhnyi, commander of the AFU, specified, 'anti-tank missiles slowed the Russians down, but what killed them was our artillery. That was what broke their units' (Reynolds and Watling 2022, 3-4).

Russia's problems were aggravated by destitute logistical support. The forward elements of the invasion force had clearly outstripped their logistics, with vehicles breaking down, others running out of fuel, and troops looting to find basic provisions like food and medical supplies (Johnson 2022, 7). However, it soon became clear that this was not temporary miscoordination,

but rather a systemic deficiency (Ti 2022, 1). Russia's logistical system was 'not organised, trained or equipped to provide the kind of expeditionary logistics that would be required for a successful campaign in Ukraine. This is a system that is not fit for purpose.' (Ti 2022, 2) The AFRF largely employed railroads and pipelines in a 'push' logistics approach, with resources allocated according to pre-determined usage rates scheduled by higher-level planning. Relatively inflexible, push logistics can work effectively in a stable conflict, however, 'this inflexibility can quickly transform into a critical vulnerability in a shifting, unpredictable tactical battlespace', (Ti 2022, 2) which was the case for Russia. This stems back to Kremlin overconfidence: the AFRF's logistics resemble a system suited for a short campaign with minor logistical needs, not a protracted war across several axes (Skoglund, Listou and Ekström 2022, 108).

At the tactical level, the Russian army fielded undertrained, demoralised and inappropriately structured units. Despite large formational combined-arms fighting being widely considered a strong point to the AFRF and suitable to the Ukrainian battlefield, Russia engaged minimal combined-arms operations above the level of battalion tactical groups (BTGs) (Dalsjö, Jonsson and Norberg 2022, 10). The Russian military is historically structured to fight in regiments, divisions and combined-arms armies with independent brigades under command (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 45). While the AFRF leadership had pursued a shift to BTGs for over a decade, institutional characteristics made the BTG construct highly problematic (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 45-46). For example, the absence of junior experience and leadership. Unlike most Western militaries that value flexible command and initiative from non-commissioned officers, the AFRF's contract structure struggles to retain experienced and educated personnel in positions of junior leadership (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 46). Compounding this limitation is the Russian military tradition of subordinate passivity (Dalsjö, Jonsson and Norberg 2022, 11). The AFRF command system encourages excessive caution and inaction, with a lack of 'ground truth.' (Freedman 2022, 13) These attitudes are less a consequence of military philosophy than of political leadership. In autocratic systems, individuals must think twice before challenging superiors. Life is easiest when they accept orders without question (Freedman 2022, 13). Moreover, as BTGs were composite formations drawing from multiple units, there was an absence of familiarity throughout personnel and command. This discordance was intensified by the BTG's ability to absorb losses. A BTG can quickly become incapable of executing a task when key enablers are disproportionately damaged, even if most components are still usable (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 46). The Russian solution to this challenge introduced even more confusion: leadership began assigning units less affected by attrition to other BTGs, intensifying chaotic command and unfamiliarity (Danylyuk et al. 2022, 46). Critically understrength, lacking adequate infantry and structure, (Jones 2022, 5) BTGs deteriorated into much-smaller units that arrived piecemeal at objectives, with calamitous results (Johnson 2022, 8).

Issues in command and unity go beyond contractual, compositional or doctrinal structure, however. The AFRF is beset by a pervasive culture of corruption and demotivation that plagues

every level of warfare. The ignorance of junior leadership denotes a historical inconsideration for the attitudes and welfare of military subordinates. Ronald Ti traces the neglect for soldier welfare back to the Russian Imperial and Red Army which was built on select officer corps with masses of peasant soldiers and little middle representation: ‘Russian soldiers have been regarded as merely expendable units, with mass (in the words of Stalin) “having a quality all of its own.”’ (Ti 2022, 3) Such Tsarist military attitudes persist to this day and have bloomed under Putin’s autocracy, typified by recent reports of unmotivated soldiers being beaten and locked in cellars (Rosenburg 2022). As Freedman states, ‘the ability to act effectively at any level of command requires a commitment to the mission and an understanding of its political purpose.’ (Freedman 2022, 23) The AFRF is severely lacking these elements, creating a dynamic that compels local initiative away from the objective at hand, and towards corrupt acts to serve individual needs and wants. The result is the incentivisation of unprofessionalism and corruption; looting, embezzlement, graft, false reporting, bribery, desertion, bullying and brutality (Kovalev 2022; Zakharov 2022; Guerin 2022).

The 2008 Russo-Georgian War was rife with such corruption and revealed a severe ‘rot’ in the AFRF from top to bottom (Dalsjö, Jonsson and Norberg 2022, 14). A large scale modernisation effort led by the *Serdyukov-Shoigu* reforms supposedly addressed such issues, (Australian Army Research Centre 2022, 5) and subsequent military success in Syria, Libya, and Crimea led the world to believe the AFRF operated through an updated cultural framework. However, Russia’s performance in Ukraine suggests that the rot ‘was never removed, but simply painted over.’ (Dalsjö, Jonsson and Norberg 2022, 14) Some argue that the Russian military produced a ‘Potemkin village of powerful armed forces with glitzy new weapons’ (Dalsjö, Jonsson and Norberg 2022, 14) or a ‘paper tiger’ (Chotiner 2022) to strengthen its claim to global power status. However, if the Kremlin understood the AFRF’s issues, the decision to invade Ukraine becomes even more bewildering. A more plausible account attributes self-deception to corruption and duplicity. As aforementioned, in autocratic political systems, paper results are valued above the truth. In a culture where corruption is normalised and rarely exposed, individuals are incentivised to inflate results or falsify information, especially when previous manipulation is probable. Consequently, one can imagine how the Kremlin received long chains of false information which spun lies of a terribly weak Ukraine and a brutally effective Russian military.

The AFRF’s underperformance has implicated a more protracted and brutal war than the Kremlin ever expected. False assumptions, hopeful rationale, and misinformation produced their entirely unrealistic strategy. After the failed forward push for Kyiv, losses were compounded by discoordination between air-ground operations as well as an abysmal logistical system unfit for purpose. The stubborn reliance on BTGs, despite their ineffectuality, intensified losses and symbolises the AFRF’s inflexibility. On the ground, troops were demoralised, unmotivated and vulnerable to corruption. The shortcomings of the Russian military cannot be compartmentalised

but are instead rooted in the culture of corruption and deceit that thrives within Putin's autocratic regime. These issues are not easily solvable and current leadership exhibits little desire to combat them and improve transparency. On the other hand, the Ukraine war has demonstrated that the main threat from Russia is not its conventional capability, but rather this self-serving craving for risk, corruption and brutality. As long as the current autocracy stays in power, unethical, immoral and inhumane malpractice will emanate from the Russian military sphere.

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